DO YOU KNOW?

Globally, about 800 women die every day of preventable causes related to pregnancy and childbirth; 20 per cent of these women are from India. Similarly India's infant mortality rate was 44 per 1,000 live. Although, India has witnessed dramatic growth over the last two decades, maternal mortality still remains high as in comparison to many developing nations.

source: *http://unicef.in*

- Creating awareness about care for pregnant women, post-natal care of mother and child and the importance of breast feeding.
- Encouraging and supporting governmental and non-governmental agencies to identify new methods and/or to improve upon the existing methods of birth control.

Health care programmes such as massive child immunization, supply of nutritional food to the pregnant women, Janani Suraksha Yojana, Janani Shishu Suraksha Karyakaram, RMNCH+A approach (an integrated approach for reproductive, maternal, new born, child and adolescent health), Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan, etc., are taken up at the national level by the Government of India.

3.2. Amniocentesis and its statutory ban

Due to small family norms and the skewed choice for a male child, female population is decreasing at an alarming rate. Amniocentesis is a prenatal technique used to detect any chromosomal abnormalities in the foetus and it is being often misused to determine the sex of the foetus. Once the sex of the foetus is known, there may be a chance of female foeticide. Hence, a statutory ban on amniocentesis is imposed.

3.3. Social impact of sex ratio, female foeticide and infanticide

The sex ratio is the ratio of males to the females in a population. In India, the child sex ratio has decreased over the decade from 927 to 919 female for every 1000 males. To correct this ratio, steps are needed to change the mind set and attitudes of people, especially in the young adults. Female foeticide and infanticide is the manifestation of gender discrimination in our society.

Female foeticide refers to 'aborting the female in the mother's womb'; whereas female **infanticide** is 'killing the female child after her birth'. These have resulted in imbalance in sex ratio. In **UNDP's GII** 2018 (United nations developmental programmes gender inequality index) reflected that India was ranked at 135 out of 187 countries due to availability of very few economic opportunities to women as compared to men.

In order to prevent female foeticide and infanticide, Government of India has taken various steps like **PCPNDT Act** (Pre-Conception and Pre-Natal Diagnostic Technique Act-1994) enacted to ban the identification of sex and to prevent the use of prenatal diagnostic techniques for selective abortion. Various measures are taken by the Government to ensure survival, provision of better nutrition, education, protection and empowerment of girls by eliminating the differences in the sex ratio, infant mortality rate and improving their nutritional and educational status. **POCSO Act** (Prevention Of Children from Sexual Offences), **Sexual harassment at workplace** (Prevention, prohibition and redressal) Act and the changes in the Criminal law based

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